



Congratulations on **your wonderful new baby!** Nothing can prepare you for how it feels to become a parent. You are likely to experience a tumult of emotions—joy may be mixed with a sense of **unreality and wonder** as you marvel at this new addition to your family. Enjoy this precious time getting to know this incredible little person.

The first 12 weeks

A new family

In addition to bonding with your baby, as a new mother it is crucial that you take care of yourself and get plenty of rest. On the following pages, you will find a snapshot of what to expect in the first 12 weeks.

If you gave birth in a hospital, you will be transferred to a ward with your new baby. If you have opted to breast-feed and haven't yet in the delivery room, you will be encouraged to do this now with support from a nurse. Rest assured that it can take time to establish feeding—both you and your baby are learning—so don't worry if you have some difficulty at first.

Once you are alone with your new baby, the reality that she is actually here may hit you, bringing with it a wide range of emotions. Your baby is likely to be asleep and you may simply spend much of the time staring at her in wonderment. Try to hold her close, preferably skin to skin, and talk to her. You are the one familiar person in this new world, the person whose voice and smell are instantly recognizable to her. If you have had a cesarean section and find it difficult to hold her, ask your partner to hold her skin to skin instead.

While you will want to share the news of your new arrival with family and friends, contact the key people

and then consider turning off your phone. These first hours with your newborn baby are best enjoyed with little interruption. Although you will be allowed visitors to the hospital, it is a good idea to keep the number of people who come to a minimum. There will be plenty of time for everyone to meet the new arrival in the weeks to come.

Going home

Depending on your circumstances, you may be discharged from the hospital two days after your baby is born (if you had a vaginal delivery) or four days later (if you had a C-section). Use the time you are in hospital to ask questions about your baby's care, from diaper-changing and bathing to feeding and sleeping.

Having responsibility for this little person may feel overwhelming, but try to relax and remember you are the best person to take care of her. Rest assured that you will visit your baby's new pediatrician within just a couple of days to check your baby's progress and offer advice and support. If you're having trouble breast-feeding, you can get back in touch with the lactation consultant at the hospital for help or use an independent lactation consultant.